Monserrate returned the affection of his young charges. Of Murad, he wrote that the ‘young prince was an ideal pupil as regards natural ability, good conduct and intellectual capacity. In all these respects it would have been hard to find any Christian youth, let alone a prince, surpassing him.’ There is something of a proud father’s delight in the Jesuit’s words, further exaggerated in his account of Murad’s battle with his uncle, Mirza Muhammad Hakim.

It was Murad, together with Man Singh, who had led the Mughal troops against Mirza Hakim in 1581, and helped obliterate his uncle’s hopes of ever challenging Akbar again. While Abul Fazl praises Murad’s courage in battling alongside Man Singh, Monserrate credits his pupil with winning the battle almost single-handedly – rallying his reluctant troops, spear in hand, declaring he would take on the enemy alone if he had to. ‘Seeing the prince’s boyish courage (for he was only twelve years old), and hearing his brave words, the troops were overcome with shame, and rallied round him.’

It may have been to his kindly tutor that Murad came with excited stories of his first-ever battle, knowing that Monserrate would lend him an indulgent ear. Akbar would not have been as doting; he said so himself once, in a critical appraisal of his neighbour Abdullah of Turan’s parenting skills. The Uzbek king, he said, ‘from excess of affection could not give [his son] paternal counsel’, instead, he offered him ‘the advices of a mother’.[59] Salim, Murad and Daniyal – each a potential heir to Akbar’s throne – should expect no such mollycoddling from the emperor.

There is no record of Humayun treating Akbar with similar harshness; but then, at twelve, Akbar feared Hemu’s bellowing elephants, not his father’s harsh tongue or heavy hand. Bairam Khan, Akbar’s Khan Baba and father figure, may have tried exerting some authority over the young padishah, but Akbar had dismissed him by the time he was eighteen. Shamsuddin Ataka, his foster father, was murdered two years later. Perhaps Akbar never quite learnt what a relationship between adult sons and their fathers could be. Or, perhaps, having spent so long building and managing his empire, the herald of a new age, Akbar was strict so that his sons would not fritter away their legacy. If so, it was terribly ironic that all three – Daniyal, Murad and Salim – took to drink like bears to honey, and that two of them did, in fact, squander what their father gave them – not his empire, but their lives.